July 2021 floods in Wallonia - what happened

Team 4 | Background for the policy brief | External sources, NOT challenge data | Accessed 29 Oct 2026

Key figures - Walloon Government, press release of 4 July 2022 [1]

- 209 of Wallonia's 262 municipalities hit; the province of Liege and the Vesdre valley hardest.
- 39 deaths (according to the police). 100,000 people affected ("sinistrees").
- 9,670 hectares under water. Nearly 48,000 buildings damaged, of which 45,000 homes. More than 11,000 cars.
- Hundreds of engineering structures destroyed or damaged, incl. 559 bridges; 160 sports facilities damaged.
- Day after: 15,000 households without gas, 66,500 without electricity, 47,000 without water.
- Cost for the Walloon Region "at this stage" (July 2022): EUR 2.8 billion.
- 152,000 tonnes of flood waste removed (plus the same again in soil and mud). Over 1,000 riverbank sites needed securing.

Timeline

- 13 July, evening: first local flooding, roads cut [2].
- 14 July: rivers peak; evacuation orders in Liege, Limburg and Luxembourg provinces; youth camps evacuated [2]. Pepinster (Vesdre / Hoegne confluence): 7 deaths, buildings collapse [2].
- 14 July, 14:00: Belgium's National Crisis Center triggers Copernicus EMS Rapid Mapping, activation EMSR518, AOI01 Liege and AOI02 Rochefort [3]. The EU Civil Protection Mechanism is activated at Belgium's request the same day [4].
- Night 14-15 July: surges in the Vesdre valley; the Vesdre (Eupen) and Gileppe dams reach maximum capacity and release water [2].
- 15 July: first Copernicus flood delineation maps delivered; monitoring maps on 17 July [3]. Rain front moves west [2].

Rainfall

- Jalhay: 271.5 mm in 48 h, almost three times the July monthly average; RMI called it a once-in-a-century event. RMI's forecast upper limit had been 100 mm [2]. Verify against RMI before citing.
- Hockai (Stavelot): 179.0 mm on 14 July, national daily record [5]. The two figures measure different periods (48 h vs 1 day).

Where - most affected ("category 1") municipalities [1]

- Chaudfontaine, Esneux, Eupen, Liege, Limbourg, Pepinster, Rochefort, Theux, Trooz, Verviers. 38 municipalities were category 1 or 2.
- Rivers: Vesdre (Eupen to Chaudfontaine), Hoegne, Ourthe (Esneux), Lesse (Rochefort), Meuse (Liege) [1][2][3].
- Link to our data: the challenge folder ems_be holds EMSR518 AOI01 and AOI02 vectors (see Annex 2 for limits).

Response and recovery [1]

- Insurance: a federal law caps insurer payouts in large disasters - insured victims would have received only 20% of assessed damage. Wallonia added EUR 1 billion; split became 41% insurers / 59% Region.
- Calamity Fund (uninsured): 7,673 claims by July 2022; staff grew from 3 to 41 people.
- 3,521 people rehoused; 600,000+ hot meals; EUR 550 energy bonus for drying homes (9,500+ households); EUR 80 million to category 1-2 municipalities.
- Reconstruction: Special Reconstruction Commissioner (until 26 July 2022); Master plan Vesdre; "sustainable neighbourhoods" (11 neighbourhoods, 9 municipalities); hydraulic modelling of the Vesdre basin; guides on building in flood zones.
- Insurers by July 2025: 73,790 claims processed, 96.2% fully paid and closed, EUR 2.24 billion paid (Assuralia) [6].
- Municipal resilience grants for flood-risk plans (PGRI 2022-2027): EUR 21.2 m + EUR 50 m = EUR 71.2 m [7].

Accountability

- Walloon Parliament inquiry commission: report in 2022 with 161 recommendations (dams, crisis management, watercourses, risk culture) [7]. The Government took note and split them between ministers in April 2022 [1].
- Independent expert analysis of dam/waterway management (Stucky, for the Walloon Government) [7]; press reports it found no negative impact of the Eupen dam but non-optimal crisis management [8].
- Warnings went to the highest level only after flooding had started; in many places evacuation orders came too late [2].

Careful with numbers

- Deaths: sources range 38-42 depending on date and count. Use 39 (police, via Walloon Government [1]).
- Cost: EUR 2.8 bn (Region's cost, 2022) and EUR 2.24 bn (insurers' payouts, 2025) measure different things - never add them.
- Scope: Wallonia only. Flanders, Germany and the Netherlands are not covered here.

Sources (all accessed 29 Oct 2026)

[1] Gouvernement wallon, "Inondations de juillet 2021 : Bilan et perspectives", press release, 4 July 2022. wallonie.be/sites/default/files/2022-07/[CP] - Inondations de juillet 2021 - Bilan et perspectives.pdf

[2] Brussels Times, "Wallonia floods five years on: How one of Belgium's worst tragedies unfolded", 13 July 2026. brusselstimes.com/2216598

[3] Copernicus EMS Rapid Mapping, activation EMSR518. mapping.emergency.copernicus.eu/activations/EMSR518/

[4] Copernicus EMS news, 16 July 2021; Wallonia/Eurisy case study (search results, not opened - verify).

[5] La Libre, "Avec un record de precipitations, l'ete 2021 est le plus humide jamais enregistre", 1 Sept 2021 (search result - open before citing).

[6] L'Avenir / Belga, "Inondations devastatrices de juillet 2021 en Wallonie : 4 ans apres...", 8 July 2025.

[7] Wallonie.be, "Inondations de juillet 2021 : Rapports, etudes, projets, subventions" (undated page).

[8] RTBF, "Rapport independant sur les inondations..." (search result - open before citing).